The Rifle

By Patrick F. McManus

INTRODUCTION

There are some lucky people out there who have better jobs or who work at jobs where they do something they like. If you are one of these people, you have to ask yourself; Do you really like your job, or do you just hate your job less than most people? If you had a choice, would you choose to work at your job for 40 hours a week? Let's face it even "you know what" would get boring after going at it 40 hours a week, 50 weeks a year. Work can spoil anything. Many people love gardening, but farm-work is hot and back-breaking. Cooking can be fun, but working as a cook in a busy restaurant is not. If you like your job now, trust me . . . . you will like your job even more if you work less. In The Rifle, Patrick finds out that working . . . . even if it is to earn money to buy something you REALLY want . . . . is not all it's cracked up to be. The Rifle by Patrick F. McManus.

At least once a week from the fifth grade on, I made it a practice to stop by Clyde Fitch's Sport Shop after school. Clyde was always glad to see me, and we would josh each other.

"Hi, Clyde," I'd say as I came through the door.

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"Don't handle the guns," Clyde would say. "You got peanut butter on one of the twelve-gauges last time. I wish you'd find someplace else to eat your after-school snack."

Before I knew what was happening, a .30-06 would have leaped into my hands and I would be checking its action.

"DON'T TOUCH THE GUNS!" Clyde Fitch would yell, doing a fair impression of an enraged businessman.

"Good, Clyde, good," I would say as I set the rifle back in the rack and peered down at a sleek, inviting .300. Apparently displeased by my lack of enthusiasm for his performance, Clyde would rush over, grab me by the back of my coat collar and belt, and rush me out the door of his establishment.

Just a few days short of eternity, my fourteenth birthday finally arrived. I had expected it to come bearing as a gift one .30-30 rifle, about which I had dropped approximately 30,000 hints to my family. No rifle! I could tell from the shapes of the packages. They were all shaped like school clothes. "Something

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seems to be missing here," I said, nervously ripping open a package of Jockey shorts. "You sure you didn't forget and leave one of my presents in the closet? I was, uh, sort of expecting a, uh, thirty-thirty rifle."

"Oh," Mom said. "Well, if you want a rifle, you'll just have to get yourself a job and earn enough money to buy one."

It was not unusual in those days for parents to say brutal things like that to their children. There were no laws back then to prevent parents from saying no and, worse yet, meaning no. Life was hard for a kid. Still, I couldn't believe that my mother was actually suggesting that her only son go out and find a job.

Naturally, I had heard about work. My family was always talking about it within range of my hearing, and as far as I could tell, seemed generally to be in favor of it. I didn't know why. Nothing I ever heard about work made it seem very appealing.

Still, if I wanted to hunt deer that coming fall, I would need a rifle. On the other hand, if I got a job, that would ruin my summer and leave me only mornings

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and evenings and weekends to fish. At best, I might be able to get in some more fishing on days I was too sick to work. I weighed my need for the rifle against a ruined summer and, after much long and painful thought, arrived at a distasteful decision: I would have to borrow a rifle.

Then, as now, people did not stand in line to loan out their rifles to beginning hunters, or to anyone else for that matter. My old friend Rancid Crabtree seemed to me to be the best prospect for the loan of a rifle.

"By the way, Rancid," I said to him casually one day, "how about loaning me your thirty-thirty for deer season this year."

Rancid's face erupted into that beautiful snaggle-toothed grin of his. "Thet's a good-un," he said. "Make it up yersef or somebody tell it to you?"

"It's no joke," I said. "I need a deer rifle, and I don't see why you can't loan me your thirty-thirty."

"Wall, Ah would loan it to you except fer one thang," Rancid said. "An' thet is, Ah don't want to."

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I shook my head in despair. "You're the only person I can think of, Rancid, who might loan me a rifle. I guess the only thing left for me to do is to get a job and earn some money."

"Now don't go talkin' like thet," Rancid said, as soon as he had recovered from the shock. "A young fella like you, got everthang to live fer, talkin' about getting' a j-j-jo – throwin' away his life. No sar, Ah won't stand fer it! Now, hyar's what you do. You go as the Inyun if you kin borry one of his rifles."

"Pinto Jack?"

"Why shore, ol' Pinto'd give you the hid offen his scrawny carcass iffin it had a zipper on it."

I found Pinto Jack puffing a pipe on the front porch of his cabin, and put my request straight to him.

Pinto Jack smiled only on rare occasions, and this was not one of them. "You want to borrow my rifle?" he said, studying me thoughtfully through a cloud of pipe smoke. "If I loaned you my rifle, what would I use when I raided the ranchers and burned their buildings and drove off their livestock, and like that?"

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"Couldn't you use a bow and arrow for a few raids?" I said.

"You tell me, how am I going to drive my old truck and shoot a bow and arrow at the same time? No, I got to have my rifle for raiding the ranchers."

I looked crestfallen, having many years before learned that this was one of the best looks to use on Pinto Jack.

"Tell you what," he said after a moment. "I could maybe let you use the old rifle my father brought back from the Great War. It's a single-shot and kicks a bit, but you're welcome to it."

I rushed home lugging the monstrous firearm, pinned a target to a fence post backed by a sandbank, paced off a hundred years, drew a bead on the target, and gently squeezed the trigger. Later I heard that all the livestock within a mile radius sprang two feet into the air and went darting about in all directions at that altitude. Apples rained down out of the trees in the orchards. Three lumberjacks swore off drink, and two atheists were converted to religion. My own

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interpretation of the event was that I had just been struck by lightning, a meteorite, or a bomb. When my vision cleared, I knew I was in trouble. Nevertheless, I decided to try one more shot, this one left-handed. The second shot went off a little better, since by now I knew what to expect. It was easier for me to keep my nose out of the way, too, because the first hot had moved it up into the vacant area above my right eyebrow where it would be safe. By the time I had finished sighting in the rifle, I figured I'd be the only kid in the school talent show who could applaud behind his back with his shoulder blades.

By the time the next summer rolled around, it had become apparent to me that the only way I was ever going to get a deer rifle was to earn the money for it. There was a dairy farmer by the name of Brown who lived nearby and whose reputation in the community was that of a kindly, if somewhat frugal, gentleman. Out of desperation for a deer rifle, I broke down and indentured myself to him at the rate of fifty cents an hour manufacturing postholes. Mr. Brown gave me the

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job after asking if I thought I could do a man's work. My ingenious reply was: "it depends on the man." The farmer said later that he supposed the particular man I had been referring to was an Egyptian mummy. For all his other drawbacks, Mr. Brown did not lack a sense of humor.

About his other drawbacks. It was only after going to work for him that I discovered that he wasn't a kindly gentleman at all but the former commandant of a slave-labor camp. Our mutual misfortune was that he had somehow missed the last boat to Brazil and had been forced to escape to Idaho, where he took up dairy farming as a cover.

"Vork, vork!" he would scream at me, slapping the leg of his bib overalls with a swagger stick. "Make die postholes, make die postholes, fahster, fahster!"

And I would streak about the landscape, trailing fresh-dug postholes. Sometimes, after glancing nervously around, I would step behind a tree to catch my breath. The farmer would drop out of the branches and

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screech at me: "Vot you do-ink? I not pay-ink you fifty zents an hour to breathe! Vork! Vork!."

At the end of the very hour in which I earned the last fifty cents I need to buy the rifle, I resigned my position. When I told the farmer I was quitting, he tried to conceal his disappointment by leaping in the air and clicking his heels. There are few things, by the way, more disgusting than a dairy farmer clicking his heels in the air.

"I'll say this for you," he told me. "You have dug what I regard to be the most expensive postholes in the whole history of agriculture. If it was possible, I would gather them all up and put them in a bank vault rather than leave them scattered randomly about my property. Nevertheless, lad, should you ever find yourself in need of a job to buy yourself, say, a shotgun, why you just come to me. I'll be happy to recommend you as a worker."

Naturally, I was flattered by this little farewell speech. I even changed my mind about his being a former commandant of a slave-labor camp. "Thanks," I

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told him, "but now that I've tried work and found it to be about what I expected, I think I'll avoid it in the future."

Mr. Brown said he thought that would be a good idea and that, as far as he had observed, I had considerable talent for that line of endeavor and was practically assured of success.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Patrick F. McManus
Book: They Shoot Canoes, Don't They
ISBN: 978-0805000306
Publisher: Holt Paperbacks
Date (Month/Year): Sept 1982

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier